

EM ASIA FX/RATES VIEWS

AI Exposure Driving Regional FX Disparity

1. AI's haves versus have-nots are driving Asian FX performance. The broad USD was on a gradual decline throughout August, but rallied after Fed Chairman Warsh's speech at Jackson Hole, which the market interpreted as hawkish. Warsh's speech suggests that a hike in September is possible if the August CPI and PPI come in firmer, but our US economists continue to expect that core CPI and PCE inflation will print around 0.2% in August and that the FOMC will remain on hold. Year-to-date Asian currency performance can be neatly explained by exposure to tech exports (Exhibit 1). The KRW, SGD, MYR, and TWD have outperformed the less tech-exposed, high-yielding currencies in Asia: INR, IDR, and PHP (Exhibit 2). The energy shock, which was more prevalent in Q2, appears to have had less impact on Asian currencies over the summer, given the dominance of the AI investment boom. The most perplexing Asian currency this year has been the KRW. Despite benefiting from record tech exports and a 100% equity market rally, the KRW was the worst-performing currency in H1 due to equity outflows. However, as we discuss below, as outflows moderated, the KRW staged a significant rally over the summer, becoming the best-performing regional currency year-to-date. Going forward, we expect USD/Asia to grind lower. Thematically, we expect the CNY to continue on its gradual appreciation path. Tech-related currencies such as KRW, TWD, and MYR should outperform NJA FX. The THB has received a boost from higher gold prices, but over the medium term, a weaker current account and negative real rate differentials should dominate. Among the high-yielding currencies, we expect USD/INR to remain range-bound between 95 and 97 now that the catalyst for the rally, namely FCNR, is behind us. We are bearish on the IDR, given BI's subtle shift toward focusing on rates, and bearish on the PHP due to elevated oil prices and inflation. We are also broadly cautious on duration, given the hiking cycle across parts of Asia.

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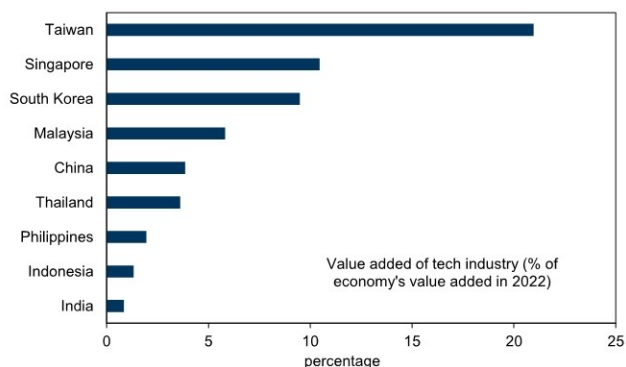
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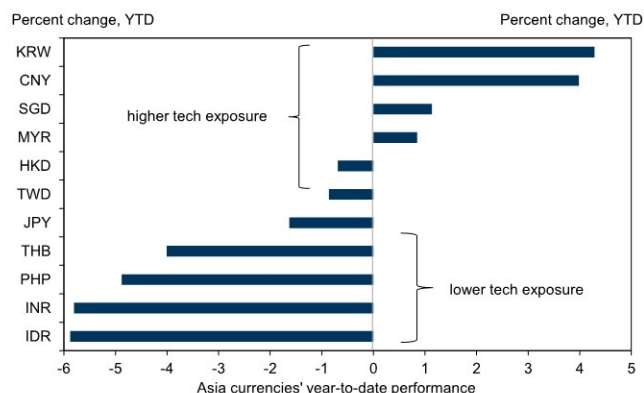
Exhibit 1: Taiwan, Singapore, South Korea and Malaysia are the most tech-oriented economies in Asia



*OECD TiVA data, latest version 2022

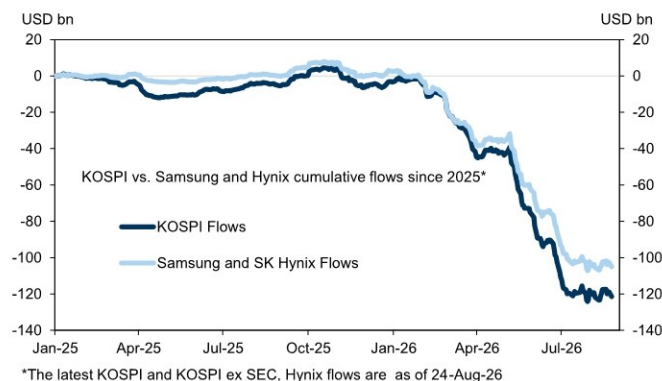
Source: OECD TiVA, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 2: AI/tech exposure currencies outperform in the EM Asia FX complex

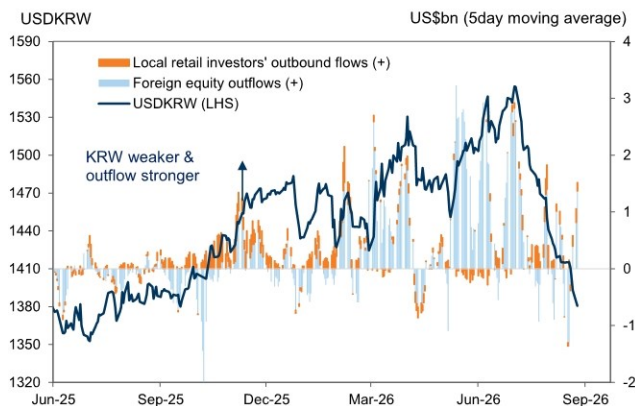


Source: Haver Analytics, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

2. South Korea - Moderating equity outflows combined with record exports drive a 12% KRW rally over the summer. The KRW experienced a large swing from being the most underperforming Asian currency in H1, due to heavy foreign equity outflows of ~USD100bn (primarily driven by index rebalancing flows), to now being the best-performing currency in Asia year-to-date after a 12% rally (vs. USD) in July and August. In H1-2026, the KOSPI's sharp outperformance relative to global equity markets, and the outperformance of two stocks within the KOSPI, led foreign investors to reduce their Korean equity exposure to manage concentration risk (Exhibit 3). However, with the KOSPI correcting by almost 30% since June, the pace of foreign equity outflows has moderated, thereby lessening the offset to the surging current account surplus, leading to the KRW's recent rally (Exhibit 4). Exports continue to beat expectations, underpinned by semiconductors. Our economists revised up their current account forecast to a record USD400bn surplus (or 19% of GDP) for 2026 from 6.5% of GDP in 2025. Although the current account surplus is set to more than triple last year's level, as we observed in H1-2026, the performance of the KOSPI (including its components) can materially influence equity flows and, in turn, the KRW. We see four broad scenarios: i) if a limited number of stocks significantly outperform the KOSPI, then we could see outflows again, as in H1; ii) if we get a broadening of the KOSPI rally, then we should see net equity inflows; iii) if the KOSPI is range-bound, then we think the KRW should outperform, led by a renewed focus on the current account; and iv) if the KOSPI declines significantly further, then we could see renewed outflows. Our equity strategists expect a broader rally in the KOSPI, which is supportive of equity inflows (or at least only moderate outflows). As such, we maintain our constructive outlook on the KRW. Given USD/KRW has broken through our prior 12M forecasts, we recently revised our forecasts to 1390, 1370 and 1350 on a 3M/6M/12M horizon from 1460, 1440 and 1420 previously.

Exhibit 3: Foreign outflows have been ~USD 120bn YTD, mostly concentrated in two stocks

Source: Bloomberg, Haver Analytics

Exhibit 4: KRW started to rally as portfolio outflows began to ease in July

Source: Haver Analytics, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

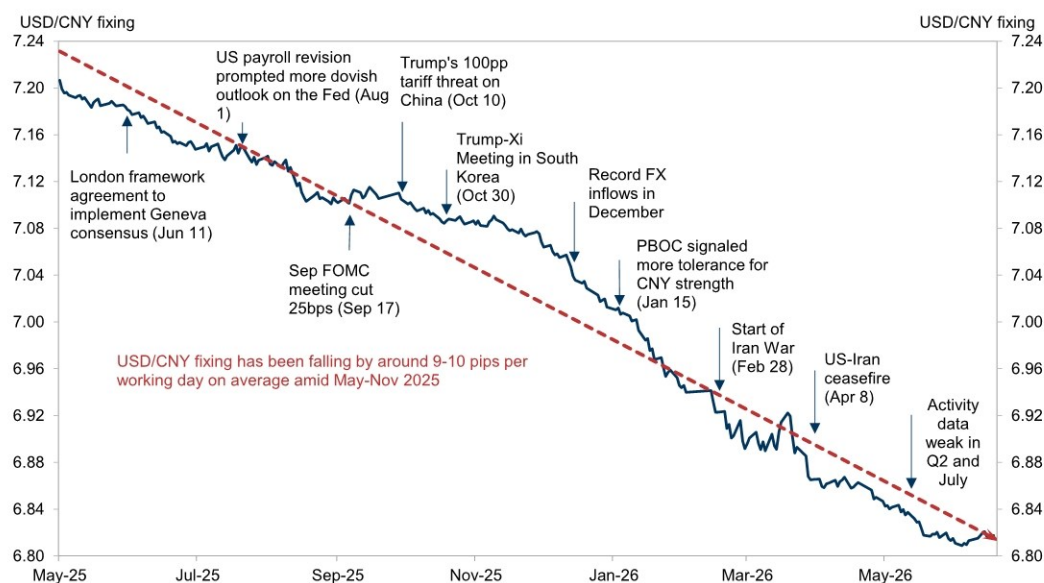
3. Bank of Korea (BoK) delivered a dovish hike in August, while excess tax revenues could see the budget deficit halved in 2027.

The BoK hiked its policy rate by 25bp in August, with consensus fairly split going into the meeting. The BoK raised its real GDP forecast for 2026 by 0.7pp to 3.3%, broadly in line with our forecast, and lifted its 2027 forecast by 0.8pp to 2.9%. The upgrade was attributed to ongoing strength in semiconductor exports, investment, and private consumption as incomes improve. The BoK kept its inflation forecasts largely unchanged at 2.7% for 2026 and 2.3% for 2027. Forward guidance was less hawkish, with the median dot projecting one 25bp hike over the next six months, compared with two hikes in the May dots. This puts the BoK's terminal rate at 3.25%, in line with our forecast for a final 25bp hike in January. A key upcoming focus is the 2027 budget, which goes to parliament for approval on 1 September. The Ministry of Planning and Budget (MPB) indicated that tax revenues could exceed KRW 500trn, or around 15% of GDP, in 2027. This could allow the budget deficit to be halved by about 2pp of GDP from 4% in 2026 (or from 1.7% of GDP to near balance on a consolidated basis). A narrower managed fiscal deficit would meaningfully reduce the government debt-to-GDP ratio to the mid-40% of GDP range in 2027, versus around 50% of GDP projected for 2026 by our economists. The net Korea Treasury Bond (KTB) issuance limit for 2026 is KRW 110trn. If the budget deficit is halved, the net KTB issuance limit could also fall by approximately half, to around KRW 60trn. Less hawkish forward guidance from the BoK, together with a likely significant reduction in KTB supply, should cap the rise in KTB yields and KRW IRS rates.

4. China - Despite slower economic growth in July, solid export growth alongside sluggish domestic demand should keep the CNY on an appreciation trend. July's activity data showed renewed growth weakness, and we estimate that official real GDP is running at around 4% yoy in early Q3, below the 4.3% yoy registered in Q2 and the government's full-year target of 4.5-5.0%. The economy remains bifurcated, with exports strong while domestic demand remains weak. We expect China's broad-based export strength to continue, and the ex-gold trade balance to widen further this year, having reached a cumulative USD1.3tn over the past 12 months. Over the past few years, policy focus has been geared toward tech innovation and high-end manufacturing. While this has increased China's manufacturing competitiveness and boosted exports, it accounts for only around 20% of China's total labor market, leaving the non-manufacturing sector relatively weaker. We think China's real GDP target of 4.5-5.0% can still be achieved. We expect faster government bond issuance in H2 2026

to support the economy, which will require PBOC monetary coordination to keep interbank funding costs low. The CNY has strengthened against the USD throughout the year, but the pace has eased from around 6% annualized in H1 to roughly half that pace since then ([Exhibit 5](#)). That said, ahead of past US-China summits, the pace of CNY fixing appreciation has tended to increase. The next summit is scheduled for 24 September. We expect the CNY to remain on an appreciation path. The CNY remains significantly undervalued versus the USD based on our valuation metrics. On a REER-adjusted basis, the CNY has actually weakened versus its trading partners over the past few years, due to China's lower inflation differentials. A gradually appreciating currency would also support further CNY internationalization and could help placate trading partners' concerns over China's growing share of global trade. With onshore spot, offshore spot, and the fix having reached and breached our 3m forecast of 6.80, we recently revised our USD/CNY forecasts stronger to 6.70, 6.60, and 6.40 over 3, 6, and 12 months, respectively. Our 12m forecast of 6.40 remains stronger than consensus and forward markets.

Exhibit 5: Pace of appreciation in CNY fixing moderated slightly in July/August but we still expect gradual CNY strengthening ahead



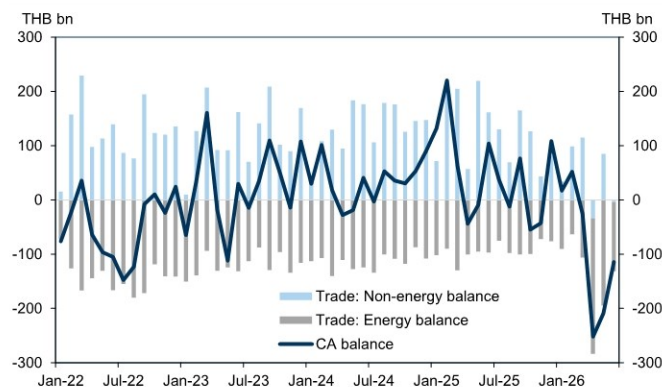
Source: Haver Analytics, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

5. Taiwan, Malaysia, Singapore - Tech-related currencies outperform. The SGD, MYR and TWD have outperformed IDR, INR and the PHP year-to-date. The MAS highlighted in its July review that robust global demand for AI-related products generated a strong expansion in exports, providing a crucial buffer against energy supply disruptions. We think this description also applies to Taiwan and Malaysia. The MAS raised the slope of the SGD NEER “very slightly” by 25bps to a 1.25% per annum appreciation path, following a 50bps steepening in April, citing the widening positive output gap and potential inflation spill-over risks. Given the “calibrated adjustment” which is smaller than the usual 50bp increment, we expect the MAS to remain on hold through the rest of 2026. With the SGD already ~1.5% above the mid-point of the SGD NEER band, we expect a gradual appreciation of the currency, as opposed to accelerated outperformance. Taiwan's exports have been growing in the vicinity of 40-60% yoy, for

most of this year, and our economists expect the current account surplus to reach a record of 25% of GDP this year (versus 20% in 2025). Nevertheless, the pace of the TWD appreciation has been a slow grind, as we think the CBC is managing the pace of appreciation. Directionally, we think TWD should continue to outperform bolstered by a strong current account and exporter USDs offshore. The MYR entered the year on the right side of the terms of trade dimension – being net long energy and part of the semiconductor supply chain, while also attracting FDI from data center build out in the region. However, state elections in Johor (in July) and Negeri Sembilan (August), briefly increased the political risk premium during the summer, prompting a bearish spell for the MYR. However, with state elections out of the way, and the Democratic Action Party (DAP) voting to stay in Prime Minister Anwar Ibrahim's coalition, we think the political risk premium should recede, with MYR likely to outperform again.

6. Thailand - Higher gold prices offset THB weakness from current account deterioration and negative real rate differentials. Thailand's economy weakened sharply in Q2, with GDP growth slowing to 1.9% yoy, from 2.9% yoy in Q1, led by declines in both private and public consumption. Private investment was the key bright spot, supported by strong data center inflows. Q2 exports improved on stronger electronics shipments, but gains were more than offset by higher oil, capital goods imports and weaker tourism receipts, which pushed the current account into a deficit (Exhibit 6). The BoT kept policy rate unchanged at 1% at their August MPC meeting. They highlighted that tracking data since the June meeting was broadly in line with expectations, although inflation has been lower than expected. Going forward, the BoT expects Q3 growth to improve as the emergency decree fiscal support mostly falls in the third quarter. Inflation should rise into Q4-Q1, but should fall back down into the target range in 2027, according to the BoT. Put together, we expect the BoT to keep rates on hold for the foreseeable future. Lower than expected inflation would give the BoT space stay on hold (and not have to respond to the region's rate hikes), while the bar to cut rates further is quite high (barring a sizable external shock), given rates are already near historical lows. On FX, the THB underperformed notably between February and June, as THB vs. USD real rate differentials narrowed and the current account deteriorated, while gold prices were on a downtrend. However, the THB has performed better over the past month, as gold prices have risen by 13% (Exhibit 7). Fundamentally, we think THB should underperform the tech-currencies in Asia, but would be reluctant to use it as a funding currency, given its gold linkages. For this reason, we recently closed our short THB/INR trade recommendation for a small potential gain of around 1%.

Exhibit 6: Thailand current account moved into deficit in Q2 on larger energy imports



Source: CEIC, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 7: Rise in gold prices appears to have driven THB's recent strength

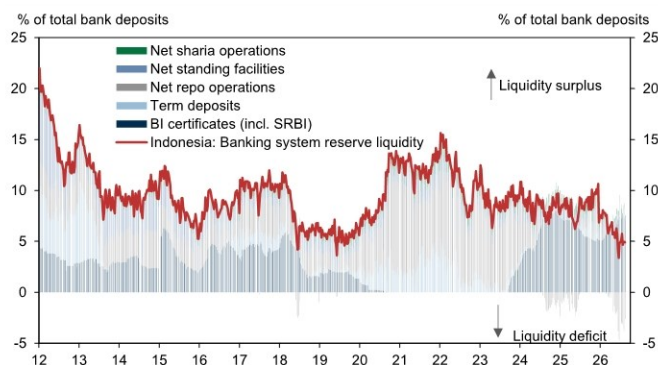


Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

7. Indonesia – Bonds supported by lower SRBI yields, but we remain cautious on the IDR as rate differentials narrow.

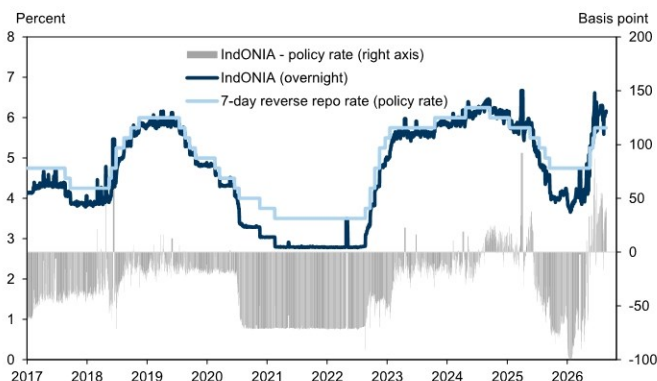
It has been an eventful month for the IDR. The unexpected resignation of BI Governor Perry Warjiyo on 27 July exerted weakening pressure on the IDR, FX, and bond markets, reinforcing foreign investor concerns over macroeconomic policy following Sri Mulyani's departure in September last year as Finance Minister. However, President Prabowo's swift nomination of Senior Deputy Governor Destry Damayanti to replace Warjiyo, alongside other BI technocratic appointments, helped revive confidence. Meanwhile, President Prabowo proposed a USD230bn budget (or fiscal deficit target of 2.4% of GDP) for 2027, the smallest planned deficit in three years. This fiscal prudence, relative to the self-imposed 3% fiscal deficit ceiling, also helped to lift market confidence. BI kept policy rates unchanged at 5.75% at its 19 August meeting, but expanded its FX hedging-cost discount scheme to cover FDI and offshore loans. BI also acknowledged that higher SRBI yields may have indirectly tightened domestic liquidity, weighing on private-sector lending ([Exhibit 8](#) and [Exhibit 9](#)). SRBI cut-off yields have been declining over the past few weeks, prompting a short covering rally in the IDR bond market. With acting BI Governor Destry indicating a preference to attract inflows through larger FX hedge discounts rather than higher SRBI yields, we think this could signal a subtle shift in the prioritization of the trade-off between FX and rates, alongside the broader macroeconomic goals. If BI is reluctant to raise policy rates or SRBI yields to attract inflows (on concerns of crowding out private-sector lending) while global core yields remain elevated, we think the IDR could become more vulnerable as IDR-core rate differentials continue to narrow.

Exhibit 8: SRBI issuance surged in 2026 as BI sought to manage FX via a steeper term structure of interest rates....



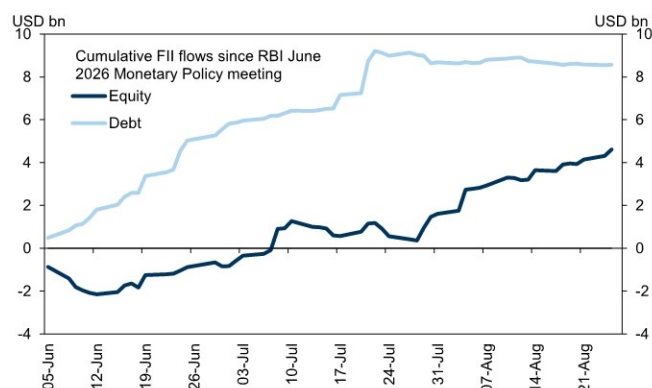
Source: Haver Analytics, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 9: ...which led to tighter interbank liquidity as reflected by higher IndONIA vs. policy rate spread

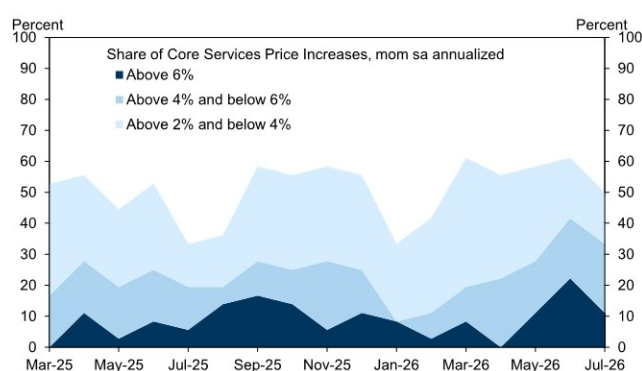


Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

8. Hawkish RBI minutes bring forward hike pricing, but December remains our base case. The August 2026 MPC minutes struck a more hawkish tone than the Governor's 5th August policy statement. At the policy meeting the RBI unanimously held the repo rate at 5.25% and retained a neutral stance, while characterizing recent inflation pressures as largely supply-driven and not broad-based. However, the 19th August minutes revealed a more hawkish tone, with Deputy Governor Gupta stating that “a case for a hike may emerge during the course of the year” given that the headline inflation is expected to peak at around 6.0% yoy in Q4 CY26. This prompted markets to bring forward tightening expectations, with the INR OIS market now pricing around 18bp of tightening at the October MPC meeting. We continue to expect 25bp hikes each in December and February, taking the terminal repo rate to 5.75%. On FX, the RBI's decision to close the FCNR(B) deposit scheme on 31st August — one month ahead of schedule — likely signals reduced balance-of-payments stress. Gross FCNR(B) deposits stood at USD 65bn as of 21st August, alongside a further USD 7.5bn raised through External Commercial Borrowings (ECBs) and Overseas Foreign Currency Borrowings (OFCBs). There has been no change to the ECB hedging facility, which we expect to remain in place through year-end, allowing for further inflows over the remainder of 2026. Improving net FDI, renewed equity inflows and stabilizing bond flows (Exhibit 10) should reduce the RBI's need to expand its already large FX forward short position, which was above USD 103bn at end-June. As such we expect USD/INR to remain broadly range-bound at 95-97 as the main catalyst for INR appreciation is now behind us. Improved external balances are unlikely to trigger sustained INR appreciation, in our view, as the RBI is likely to use episodes of INR strength to rebuild reserves and reduce its forward liabilities.

Exhibit 10: India's debt and equity inflows improved in July and August

Source: Haver Analytics, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

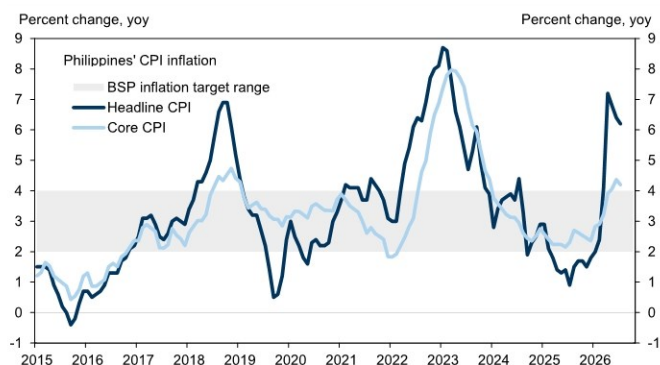
Exhibit 11: Services inflation remains relatively well contained; therefore we expect the RBI to adopt a wait-and-see at the October MPC meeting

Source: Haver Analytics, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

9. Philippines - Volatile energy prices, risk of severe El Niño and potential wage hikes keep inflation outlook elevated.

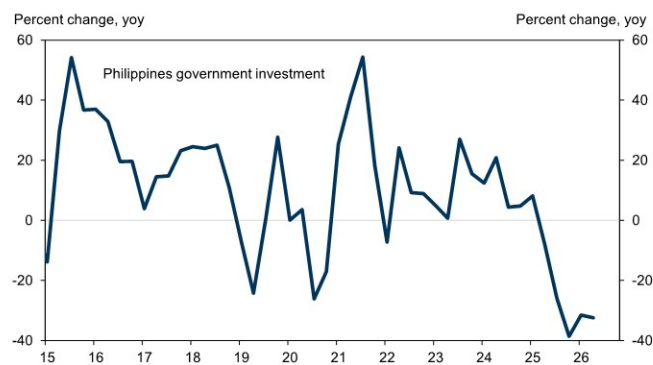
The BSP raised its policy rate by 25bp to 5.0% in August, in line with our expectations. The central bank characterized the move as pre-emptive, aimed at preventing persistent core inflation, wage pressures, and potential El Niño-related supply shocks from spilling over into broader price gains. The BSP lowered its year-end 2026 headline inflation forecast slightly to 6.1% (from 6.4% previously), as lower oil prices are offset by the potential impact from a severe El Niño, which is likely to push up rice prices, as well as potential wage hikes. The Governor said during a press briefing that although the BSP has lowered its 2026 inflation forecast, it is still elevated versus their 3% target ([Exhibit 12](#)), and therefore the BSP must maintain vigilance. Looking ahead, the BSP lifted the 2027 inflation forecast to 5.4% yoy (from 4.5% previously). Meanwhile, the Philippines' growth momentum weakened further in Q2, with real GDP growth slowing to 2.3% yoy from 2.8% in Q1. The breakdown shows that public investment has been very weak ([Exhibit 13](#)). As we highlighted from our [recent trip to the Philippines](#), we and the private sector are skeptical that public investment can pick-up easily, since the slowdown was prompted by increased scrutiny on projects following the flood prevention corruption scandal in Q3 last year. Upside risks to inflation remain meaningful, particularly with energy prices still elevated and Middle East tensions unresolved. We expect two more 25bp hikes by the BSP in this cycle to 5.50%. Given still elevated oil prices, high inflation, weak growth and current account, we maintain our bearish outlook on the PHP.

Exhibit 12: Philippines inflation remains elevated and well above the 2-4% target range



Source: Haver Analytics, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 13: Public investment remains depressed, resulting in a significant drag on growth



Source: CEIC, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Summary tables

Exhibit 14: Our views on relative performance of NJA FX and rates (3 month outlook)

	FX outlook*	Rates outlook**	Comments
China	Bullish	Neutral	Export strength, FX undervaluation and policymakers' desire for CNY internationalisation underpins our bullish CNY view. Weak growth should keep the PBoC on a dovish stance.
Korea	Bullish	Neutral	Reduced foreign equity outflows have lessened offset to surging current account surplus, paving way for KRW rally. Rangebound or broadening of KOSPI rally should be positive for KRW.
Taiwan	Bullish	Neutral	Robust trade surplus from tech exports and large accumulation of USD deposits present asymmetric risk for TWD strength. Neutral on TWD rates, as we expect CBC to remain on hold.
Hong Kong	Neutral	Neutral	Broad USD weakening has pushed USD/HKD away from the top of the convertibility band; we expect spot to stay rangebound from here.
India	Neutral	Bullish	The RBI closed the FCNR scheme early. With the catalyst for INR rally now behind us, we turn neutral on USD/INR. We like INR 30Y bonds for structural reasons.
Singapore	Neutral	Neutral	MAS steepened the SGD NEER slope by 25bp to 1.25% in July. Given the "recalibration" we think MAS's move was a one-off and do not expect further tightening this year.
Thailand	Bearish	Neutral	Higher gold prices have pushed THB stronger in the past month; we remain bearish on the THB from a weaker CA and negative real rate differentials with the USD. BoT to stay on hold.
Malaysia	Bullish	Neutral	With the state elections out of the way, we think political risk premium should lessen. Given the solid growth, strong export and FDI outlook, we remain constructive the MYR.
Indonesia	Bearish	Neutral	There may be a subtle shift in BI's prioritization between rates and FX. Lower SRBI yields is supportive for bonds, but narrower IDR vs. USD rate differentials make the IDR more vulnerable.
Philippines	Bearish	Bearish	Energy, El Nino and potential wage hikes keep the inflation outlook elevated. Given this backdrop, weak growth and weak CA outlook, we remain bearish on the PHP.

*Performance of spot and carry relative to Asian peers; ** Rates market outlook vs. current yield level (reference to 5Y swaps or bond yields)
 Italics denote a change from our previous stance.

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 15:

Trade Ideas in EM Asia rates and FX

Open trades	Initiated	Current	Entry	Target	Stop	Total PnL (capital and carry)
Long INR 30-year bonds	26-Jun-26	7.50%	7.34%	6.90%	7.65%	- 16bps
Short SGD/MYR	23-Jan-26	3.17	3.13	2.90	3.30	- 1.3%

*Target / Spot-loss levels are expressed in index terms to incorporate the total returns from; i) duration, ii) carry and iii) spot FX where appropriate.

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 16:

Closed trades	Initiated	Closed	Entry	Closed	Total PnL (capital and carry)
Short THB/INR	12-Jun-26	18-Aug-26	2.91	2.88	+1.5%
Receive THB THOR 2Y OIS	23-Jan-26	9-Mar-26	1.20%	1.13%	+15bps
Long PHP 5Y bond FX-hedged	5-Aug-25	5-Mar-26	5.93%	5.77%	+32bps
Long INR 30Y bonds FX-hedged	5-Sep-25	11-Feb-26	7.22%	7.47%	+20bps
KRW 2Y IRS	18-Nov-25	4-Feb-26	2.80%	3.16%	-35bps
Short SGD/TWD	3-Oct-25	7-Jan-26	23.57	24.6	-3.80%
Short THB/KRW	10-Jan-25	9-Sep-25	42.3	43.74	-3.30%
Long 1Y SRBIs fully FX hedged	3-Oct-24	21-Jul-25	6.82%	6.58%	+112bp
Long 2Y CGBs	6-Apr-25	16-May-25	1.47%	1.47%	0bp
Receive INR 2Y NDOIS	28-Jan-25	16-May-25	6.08%	5.48%	+44bp
Long KRW 2s10s IRS Steepener	4-Sep-24	16-May-25	-12bp	20bp	+9bp
Long INR vs. Asian FX basket (CNH, TWD, THB, MYR, and SGD with equal weights)	6-Jan-25	3-Apr-25	100	100.33	+33bp
Long 5Y CGB on a FX-hedged basis	17-Nov-24	21-Feb-25	1.69%	1.55%	+14bp
Long INR vs. Asian FX basket (CNY, KRW, TWD, THB, MYR, SGD and JPY with equal weights)	17-Nov-24	6-Jan-24	100	100.48	+114bp
Long 2Y IGBs FX-unhedged	29-Feb-24	6-Nov-24	7.02%	6.50%	+3.8%
Pay THB 2Y THOR OIS	7-Aug-24	1-Oct-24	2.02%	2.04%	+8bp
Short CNY vs. CFETS basket	9-Aug-24	30-Sep-24	100	103	-0.7%
Short EUR/INR	12-Jan-24	21-Aug-24	90.91	93	-0.3%
Rec SGD 2Y SORA OIS vs. basket of global 2Y rates	14-Apr-23	6-Aug-24	-8bp	-28bp	+42bp
Short THB/KRW	15-Mar-24	26-Jul-24	37.17	38.31	-2.7%
Long THB 3Y bonds vs. paying 3Y THOR swaps	10-Jan-24	10-Jul-24	-20	-10	+10bp
Long 1Y CGB (FX hedged)	10-Nov-23	27-Apr-24	2.25%	1.65%	+60bp
Long 10Y INDOGBs FX-unhedged	14-Dec-23	17-Apr-24	6.60%	6.75%	-15bp
Short TWD/KRW	13-Jun-23	15-Mar-24	41.42	41.83	+0.3%
Short MYRTHB	10-Nov-23	7-Feb-24	7.63	7.48	+2.0%
Short IDR 10Y vs. INR 10Y government bonds	10-Nov-23	14-Dec-23	51bp	47bp	+4bp
Receive INR 1Y ND-OIS	1-Sep-23	10-Nov-23	6.97%	6.87%	+8bp
Short PHP/INR	13-Jun-23	25-Aug-23	1.47	1.46	1.2%
Long IDR 5Y bonds USD-hedged basis	10-Feb-23	18-Aug-23	6.32%	6.15%	+27bp
Short USD/THB	17-Jul-23	4-Aug-23	34.65	34.60	+0bp
Short SGD/MYR	13-Jan-23	25-May-23	3.28	3.4	-3.70%

Disclosure Appendix

Reg AC

We, Danny Suwanapruti, Chris Poh, Xinquan Chen, Lisheng Wang, Irene Choi, Gooheon Kwon, CFA, Arjun Varma, Santanu Sengupta and Andrew Tilton, hereby certify that all of the views expressed in this report accurately reflect our personal views, which have not been influenced by considerations of the firm's business or client relationships.

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Disclosures

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